

Indian and Imly restaurants.

Ankur Jain, chief architect, Gold's Gym India, added, "Fitness is one of the most competitive segments of the lifestyle industry. It is extremely important for us to offer high-end beautiful ambience to our consumers. LED filament bulbs with their warm and victorian looks have become a mandate for all our centres. I am willing to spend extra 25-30 per cent than what I currently do on local bulbs if a good brand for LED filament bulbs is available."

Nitin Kapoor, owner of Unplugged Courtyard, shared, "We as consumers suffer the most due to absence of a good brand in the segment. Currently, bulbs are imported from China and sold by local vendors."

At the same time, interior designers are customising the LED lighting design to beautify homes, bars, restaurants, stores and hotels. Silky Arora, an interior designer, shared, "We are currently working on a few residential designs, where customers have specially demanded a certain style of LED bulbs for their bar and garden decor."

The business perspective

Companies like Havells and Philips do offer LED filament bulbs in the market, but the options are limited. In comparison, local suppliers offer much wider choice in design and power output. It is believed that low thermal capacity limits the bigger brands' interest in LED filament bulbs.

However, with improvements in technology and realisation of LED filament bulbs' benefits like 360-degree light emission and design flexibility, well-established brands have started to consider these as a separate business segment.

Devasish Ganguli, assistant general manager, Havells, shared, "Havells is the only company in India that manufactures LED filament lamps locally at their Neemrana plant. One needs to comply with

certain BIS standards to manufacture LEDs in India, and the laws are bound to become more stringent in the coming years. Currently, LED filament bulbs are used primarily in the hospitality industry. Due to limited demand, their prices are high. Earlier, even an LED bulb used to cost ₹ 300, but as the demand and supply gap reduced, the cost came down to ₹ 50. LED filament bulb's cost will also come down as their demand increases."

Build your brand strategy now

With the craze for LED filament bulbs growing all over the world, these are here to stay. The yellow light is soon expected to spill over the home decor segment. Covered in aesthetics and fuelled by engineering, LED filament bulbs are the first choice of the next generation. So now is the best time to seize the opportunity and build a great brand! **EFY**

—Nidhi Arora, executive editor, EFY

The Benefits Of Automated Fare Collection

➤ **Automated fare collection reduces waiting time and effort, multiplying customer satisfaction**

Commuter management in India's public transport system has dramatically improved after the introduction of automated fare collection (AFC) systems. While the footfall during peak office hours is increasing, queues are getting smaller and waiting times shorter. Other businesses like retail stores, paid parking and movie theatres

can also benefit greatly by investing in AFC setups for customer transaction.

The complete AFC setup

In comparison to conventional magnetic token systems, AFC systems today adopt a more efficient contactless technology facilitated by smart cards to accept, record and display fare-related queries to users as well as customers. The AFC setup is an end-to-end solution consisting of multiple components including:

1. Front-end device to collect the fare or validate a payment. Examples include vending machines, hand-held ticket generators and card recharge machines. These devices can either be used by a representative of the business organisation to serve the customer, or be available to the customers as a self-service kiosk.

2. Station system deployed near the premises of an infrastructure installation, for example, the metro station, bus stand, ticket counter and so on. Transaction data from the front-end devices is received and collected in this system, and forwarded to the central server.

3. Central system connected to the server. It is the main information collection system as it stores transaction data from all the machines. The administrator can access this information and take necessary action.

4. Contactless smart card, which has an embedded chip that communicates with the terminal based on radio frequencies. The card initiates transactions, access and data to users at terminals.

The benefits

Significantly improved customer service. AFC systems allow quick service as well as self-service options, ensuring minimal or no waiting time for consumers. Faster validation of transactions allows the staff to generate fare tokens and